

You cannot protect time you cannot see. Most of us only notice the cost of a yes two weeks later, at 10 p.m., doing the thing we never wanted to do. For the next seven days, write down every yes as it happens. Big or small. Work or home. Then fill in what it cost.

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At the end of the week, add it up

1. How many hours went to yeses you marked N?

2. Which cost shows up most often? Sleep, family, health, your own work?

3. Circle the one N you most want back. What is it?

4. Write the sentence you will use to hand it back.

Stuck on the wording? The free Say No Scripts on laurenfine.com/resources have twelve ready to use.

FROM HERE ON

One in, one out

Before you say yes to anything new, name what it replaces. If you cannot name it, you have not decided yet. You have only agreed.

My next yes will replace: _____

Try it for two weeks. Hand back one thing. Keep the invoice going. At the end of two weeks, look at what you got back.



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Lauren Fine is a coach, TEDx speaker, and story strategist helping people at every inflection point identify, shape, and tell the story of who they're becoming. She is a physician, medical educator, Harvard Macy Institute faculty, and the founder of ReasonDx.

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A free 55-minute session

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